

FCPS ACE Italian 200 - Notes

SG

June 4, 2026

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Preface

This document holds notes for the class I took in Spring 2026, *Italian 200 for Beginners and Travelers*. Each class is a chapter. The notes closely match what we cover in class, with additional comments, explanations for my own use, and examples I've picked up. The notes may (likely do!) contain mistakes.

Chapter 1

Apr 27

Topics *Intro to the past tense. Sentences with the past tense. Grammar analysis.*

1.1 Grammar

1.1.1 Past tense - *passato prossimo*

In English, ‘I have spoken’ and ‘I spoke’ are grammatically equivalent in everyday use. In Italian, everyday speech and writing uses the latter form, with *essere* and *avere* acting as helper verbs. The past tense therefore uses a three-word structure: *subject, helper-verb, past-participle*.

Broadly speaking, transitive verbs use *avere* and intransitive verbs and verbs of motion use *essere*. See [Fil19] and [Rag63] for more explanation.

Verbs that require *essere*

- *essere*
- *stare*
- *entrare*
- *arrivare*
- *venire*
- *andare*
- *uscire*
- *partire*

To form the past participle, remove the ending of the verb (e.g., *-are*, *-ere*, *-ire* and then add *-ato*, *-uto*, *-ito* to match. If *essere* is the helper verb, then change the ending to match gender and plurality.

- *comprare* → *comprato*
- *lavorare* → *lavorato*
- *vedere* → *visto*
- *arrivare* → *arrivato* or *arrivata*, *arrivati*

Unsurprisingly, some verbs are irregular and you just have to learn them.

Examples

- I’m happy because my wife made a really great dish of pasta last night. We watched a good move after dinner.

	Helper: avere Verb: comprare
io	<i>ho comprato</i>
tu	<i>hai comprato</i>
lui/lei	<i>ha comprato</i>
noi	<i>abbiamo comprato</i>
voi	<i>avete comprato</i>
loro	<i>hanno comprato</i>

Table 1.1: Past tense example: *avere + comprare*

	Helper: essere Verb: andare
io	<i>sono andato</i>
tu	<i>sei andato</i>
lui	<i>è andato</i>
lei	<i>è andata</i>
noi	<i>siamo andati</i>
voi	<i>siete andati</i>
loro	<i>sono andati</i>

Table 1.2: Past tense example: *essere + andare*

Io sono felice perché mia moglie ha fatto un piatto di pasta molto buono ieri sera. Noi abbiamo visto un buon film dopo cena.

- I said that I worked a lot today and am tired. I don't want to go to the restaurant for dinner. I prefer to stay at home.
Ho detto che ho lavorato molto oggi e sono stanco. Io non voglio andare al ristorante per cena. Preferisco stare a casa.

1.2 Grammar analysis - sentence corrections

- Test: *Io non sono comprando una casa in Italia perché è molto cara.*
Should be: *Io non sto comprando una casa in Italia perché è molto cara.*
Correction: use *stare* with present participle.
- Test: *Io non posso parla adesso perché io sto lavorando.*
Should be: *Io non posso parlare adesso perché io sto lavorando.*
Correction: use infinitive *parlare* with helper verbs.
- Test: *Mio libro è molto difficile.*
Should be: *Il mio libro è molto difficile.*
Correction: Need article with possessives except for family.
- Test: *Io mangio questo piatto di pasta perché è molto buono.*
Should be: *Io mangio questa piatto di pasta perché è molto buono.*
Correction: Need to use *questa* to match gender of pasta, not *piatto*.

Past participle	Helper: avere Irregular verbs
said, told	<i>detto</i>
made, did	<i>fatto</i>
read	<i>letto</i>
seen, saw	<i>visto</i>
put	<i>messo</i>
wrote, written	<i>scritto</i>

Table 1.3: Irregular past participles: all with *avere*

Chapter 2

May 4

Topics *Direct and indirect object pronouns, Sentence review*

2.1 Grammar

2.1.1 Direct object pronouns

A direct object pronoun replaces the noun object in a sentence. In English this corresponds to ‘it’, ‘he/she’, or ‘them’. I eat *it*. He saw *her*. They stand in for whatever thing or person the verb is acting on.

Note the subtle distinction between who/what the verb is acting *on* and who/what the verb is acting *for*. Direct object pronouns are for the person or thing that the verb is acting *on*.

Direct object pronouns in Italian replace nouns to avoid repetition. They answer the questions ‘what?’ or ‘whom?’ in relation to the verb. The pronoun goes before the conjugated verb.

	pronoun
me	<i>mi</i>
you	<i>ti</i>
him/it	<i>lo</i>
her/it	<i>la</i>
us	<i>ci</i>
you pl.	<i>vi</i>
them, masc.	<i>li</i>
them, fem.	<i>le</i>

Table 2.1: Direct object pronouns

In the past (perfect) tense, the past participle must be modified, even with *avere*, to match the gender/plurality of the pronoun, as if it is working as an adjective. Also, the *lo*, *li* forms contract to *l’* before the *h*, e.g. *La macchina? Sì, l’ho vista*.

Examples

- I eat gelato. → I eat it.
Mangio gelato. → Lo mangio.
- I love pizza. I eat pizza every day. → I love pizza. I eat it every day.
Amo la pizza. Mangio la pizza ogni giorno. → Amo la pizza. La mangio ogni giorno.
- They saw me at the restaurant.
Mi hanno visto al ristorante.
- She saw the paintings in the museum. → She saw them in the museum.
Ha visto i quadri nel museo → Li ha visto nel museo.
- I bought the car. I bought it.
Ho comprato la macchina. L'ho comprata.
- Ho visto che tu l'hai comprato già.
I saw that you had already bought it. (masc.)
- Ho visto che tu l'hai comprata già.
I saw that you had already bought it. (fem.)

2.1.2 Indirect object pronouns

These pronouns are used to indicate who or what is receiving the effect of the verb. I wrote *him* a letter. He gave *her* the book.

Look for verbs like *dare*, *scrivere*, *telefonare*, *dire*, *parlare*, *chiedere* when considering if an indirect object pronoun is appropriate, since all these verbs have some kind of target (recipient): to give (someone) something, to write (to someone), to phone (someone), to tell (someone), to speak (to someone), to ask (someone).

Indirect object pronouns indicate the recipient or beneficiary of the action, answering ‘to whom?’ or ‘for whom?’ the action is done. If you could say, ‘I [verb] to [name] something’, then [name] can become an indirect pronoun.

	English	Italian
to/for	me	<i>mi</i>
	you	<i>ti</i>
	him	<i>gli</i>
	her	<i>le</i>
	us	<i>ci</i>
	you pl.	<i>vi</i>
	them	<i>gli</i>

Table 2.2: Indirect object pronouns

Tip: if in doubt, decide what the verb is acting upon (the direct object), and to whom or for whom the action is done (the indirect object).

Examples

- I told you that I bought the ice cream for tonight.
Ti ho detto che ho comprato il gelato per questa sera.
- I told you already that I worked a lot last night.
Ti ho detto già che ho lavorato molto ieri sera.
- I'm writing a letter to Marco. → I'm writing him a letter.
Scrivo una lettera a Marco. → Gli scrivo una lettera.
- I gave the book to Elena. → I gave the book to her.
Ho dato il libro a Elena. → Le ho dato il libro.

2.2 Sentence review

- I'm happy because my wife already bought a table for our living room. We needed this table for when we have guests for dinner. The table is big and is for twelve people. I'm happy that she has already bought it.
Sono felice perché mia moglie ha già comprato un tavolo per il nostro soggiorno. Abbiamo bisogno di questo tavolo quando abbiamo ospiti per cena. Il tavolo è grande ed è per dodici persone. Sono felice che lo ha comprato già.
- Hi Giorgio! I called you last night but you didn't answer. I hope everything is OK. I'm working a lot these weeks. I told you that I wanted to go on vacation with you and your family. Let's talk about that soon. See you soon!
Ciao Giorgio! Ho ti chiamato ieri sera, ma tu non hai risposto. Spero tutto bene. Sto lavorando molto queste settimane. Ti ho detto che voglio andare in vacanza con te e la tua famiglia. Parliamo di questo presto. A presto!

Chapter 3

May 11

Topics *Pronouns recap, Sentence review, Conversation, Vocabulary*

3.1 Grammar

3.1.1 Disjunctive pronouns

These pronouns are used as objects for prepositions like ‘for’ *per*, ‘between’ *tra*, ‘to’ *a*, and ‘of’ *di*. They are also used for emphasis and for some comparisons.

Disjunctive pronouns pair with prepositions, not verbs. You might think of them as adding color or clarification to the action in a sentence. Their name describes how they are separated from (disjunct from) the verb.

When to use disjunctive pronouns

- With prepositions: *con, da, per, senza, su, tra, ...*
- For comparison with *come* and *quanto* (‘as/like’, ‘as much as’)
- For emphasis

	pronoun
me	<i>me</i>
you	<i>te</i>
him	<i>lui</i>
her	<i>lei</i>
him/herself	<i>sè</i>
us	<i>noi</i>
you pl.	<i>voi</i>
them	<i>loro</i>
themselves	<i>sè</i>

Table 3.1: Disjunctive pronouns

Examples

- Are you coming to the cinema with me?
Vieni con me al cinema?
- I talked about you to Marco.
Ho parlato di te a Marco.
- I'm doing it for them, not for you.
Lo faccio per loro, non per te.
- She works harder than us, it's incredible.
Lavora più di noi, è incredibile.
- She's as smart as he is.
È intelligente quanto lui.
- He called me, not you.
Ha chiamato me, non te.
- I live near them.
Abito vicino a loro.
- She always talks about him.
Parla sempre di lui.

3.1.2 Pronouns recap

- **Subject pronouns:** I, you, we, you (pl.), them → *io, tu, noi, voi, loro*
- **Direct object pronouns:** What/whom (me, you, him/it, her/it, us, you (pl.), them) → *mi, ti, lo, la, ci, vi, li, le*
- **Indirect object pronouns:** Recipient: to/for me, you, him, her, us, you (pl.), them → *mi, ti, gli, le, ci, vi, gli*
- **Disjunctive pronouns:** me, you, him, her, us, you (pl.), them → *me, te, lui, lei, noi, voi, loro*

Examples

- I'll pay (it)
Lo pago.
- I bought him a gelato.
Gli ho comprato un gelato.
- I want to go to the store with you.
Voglio andare al negozio con te.
- Claudio went with us to the store.
Claudio è andato con noi al negozio.

3.2 Sentence review

- I told my wife to buy pizza for dinner. She told me, "I bought it."
Ho detto mia moglie comprare la pizza per cena. Mi ha detto, "L'ho comprata."
- My son wants ice cream this evening. I bought it.
Mio figlio vuole il gelato questa sera. L'ho comprato.
- I didn't go to the store to buy milk and bread.
Non sono andato al negozio per comprare il latte e il pane.
- I would like to make pizza this weekend.
Vorrei fare la pizza questo fine settimana.
- I worked in my garden yesterday.
Ho lavorato nel mio giardino ieri.
- I walked with my dog today.
Ho camminato con il mio cane oggi.
- I took my dog for a walk.
Ho porto a spasso il mio cane.
- I'm buying milk because I need to have breakfast tomorrow morning.
Sto comprando latte perché ho bisogno di fare colazione domani mattina.
- I went to the store to buy milk for my wife.
Sono andato al negozio per comprare il latte per mia moglie.
- Cake? I'm sorry, I haven't bought it because I still have gelato in the fridge.
La torta? Mi dispiace, non l'ho comprata perché io ho ancora gelato nel frigorifero.
- I haven't bought it yet.
Non l'ho mangiata ancora.

3.3 Conversation

F *Come state?*

A *Non c'è male.*

P *Sto bene ma, sono piuttosto stanca in questi giorni perché ho lavorato lo scorso fine settimana.*

S *Sono contento perché finalmente ho comprato la Lamborghini.*

F *Congratulazioni. Dove l'hai comprata?*

S *L'ho comprata da un amico. Un buon affare.*

P *La vorrei vedere.*

S *Potete venire con me al ristorante questa sera. Se potete.*

F *Mi dispiace. Non posso... sto ancora lavorando.*

P *Sono disponibile. A che ora?*
 A *Anche io posso venire. Quale ristorante.*
 S *Non ti preoccupare. Vi prendo.*
 F *Che peccato! Non posso venire.*
 P *La prossima volta, F.*
 S *Alle otto va bene per voi?*
 A *Facciamo alle otto e trenta per favore.*
 P *Non è un problema.*
 F *Buon divertimento!*

3.4 Vocabulary

3.4.1 Phrases

Table 3.2 has the basics.

I can't complain	<i>Non c'è male</i>	rather	<i>piuttosto</i>
last	<i>scorso</i>	A good deal	<i>Un buon affare</i>
available	<i>disponibile</i>	I'll pick you up	<i>Io vi prendo</i>
What a shame	<i>Che peccato</i>	8:30	<i>otto e mezza, otto e trenta</i>
Have fun!	<i>Buon divertimento!</i>		

Table 3.2: Phrases

Chapter 4

May 18

Topics *Pronouns recap, Conversation*

4.1 Grammar

4.1.1 Pronouns recap

- **Subject pronouns.** Who is doing the action of the sentence: I, you, we, you (pl.), them → *io, tu, noi, voi, loro*
- **Direct object pronouns:** What/whom is being acted on: me, you, him/it, her/it, us, you (pl.), them → *mi, ti, lo, la, ci, vi, li, le*
- **Indirect object pronouns:** Who is the recipient of that action: to/for me, you, him, her, us, you (pl.), them → *mi, ti, gli, le, ci, vi, gli*
- **Disjunctive pronouns:** Extra info with prepositions like ‘for’, ‘between’, etc: <preposition> + me, you, him, her, us, you (pl.), them → *me, te, lui, lei, noi, voi, loro*

Example

Consider: ‘Luigi gave the book to Luca yesterday, not to Isabella.’ With pronouns this becomes: ‘He gave it to him yesterday, not to her.’

- Luigi → subject pronoun ‘He’ → *lui*
- gave → verb *ha dato*
- the book → direct object pronoun ‘it’ → *lo*
- to Luca → indirect object pronoun ‘to him’ → *gli*
- yesterday → *ieri*
- not → *non*
- to Isabella → preposition ‘to’ and disjunctive pronoun ‘her’ → *a lei*

Step by step walkthrough

1. Focus on the main clause, ‘He gave it to him’.

2. Rule: indirect pronoun comes before direct, so we translate right-to-left: [to him] [it] [he gave].
¹
3. This gets us: *Gli + lo + ha dato*.
4. Rule: indirect + direct combos may contract or change form - see 4.1.
5. New form: *Glielo + ha dato*.
6. Add in ‘yesterday’ and the preposition ‘not’ and the disjunctive ‘to her’.
7. *Glielo ha dato + ieri + non + a lei*.
8. Result: *Glielo ha dato ieri non a lei*.

When indirect and direct pronouns are used together, their forms change to flow more naturally. For example, *mi li* becomes *me li*. See 4.1.

indirect	+ direct	→ Result	Example	
<i>mi</i>	<i>lo/la/li/le</i>	<i>me lo/la/li/le</i>	<i>Me lo dice</i>	He says it to me.
<i>ti</i>	<i>lo/la/li/le</i>	<i>te lo/la/li/le</i>	<i>Te lo porto</i>	I bring it to you.
<i>gli</i>	<i>lo/la/li/le</i>	<i>glielo/la/li/le</i>	<i>Glieli lo già dati</i>	I already gave them to him.
<i>le</i>	<i>lo/la/li/le</i>	<i>glielo/la/li/le</i>	<i>Glielo scrivo</i>	I write it to her.
<i>ci</i>	<i>lo/la/li/le</i>	<i>ce lo/la/li/le</i>	<i>Ce li danno</i>	They give them to us.
<i>vi</i>	<i>lo/la/li/le</i>	<i>ve lo/la/li/le</i>	<i>Ve li mostro</i>	I show them to you (pl.)
<i>loro</i>	<i>lo/la/li/le</i>	<i>lo/la/li/le + verb + loro</i>	<i>Lo do loro</i>	I give it to them.

Table 4.1: Indirect and Direct Object pronoun combinations

4.1.2 Pronouns after the verb

Normally pronouns go before the verb: *Me lo dice*, for example. However, with modal verbs (can, must, want), imperatives, and some expressions (‘without’, ‘instead of’, ‘after’, + verb) they go after.

Examples

- I can buy it
Posso comprarlo.
- Eat it! (gelato)
Mangialo!
- Instead of reading it, buy it.
Invece di leggerlo, comprarlo.
- I can write it, without studying it.
Posso scriverlo, senza studiarlo.
- After driving it, I don’t want to buy it.
Dopo guidarla, non voglio comprarla.

¹Exception to this rule is when *loro* when used as indirect pronoun - it comes after the verb.

- I can't buy it without trying it.
Non posso comprarlo senza provarlo.
- I don't want to buy you gelato now.
Non voglio comprarti gelato adesso.
- I don't want to buy her gelato now.
Non voglio comprarle gelato adesso.

4.2 Conversation

P *Sono stanca perché sto lavorando troppo*

A *Mi dispiace. Tu dovresti parlare con il tuo capo.*

F *Buona idea. Non pensare a questo. Comprati un gelato.*

S *Non ti preoccupare. Andiamo al ristorante questa sera.*

P *Grazie mille, ma, io devo andare al bar con una mia amica.*

A *Facciamo domani sera.*

F *Io sono disponibile domani sera verso le sette di sera.*

P *Perfetto. Ci vediamo domani sera.*

Appendix

Class dates

Apr	27			
May	04	11	18	25
Jun	01	08	15	

Table 2: Class dates

Resources

Things I have found during class. (References should be clickable.)

Books

- [[Rag63](#)]: Very old-fashioned, but the book is slim and quick to read.

Online

- [[Fil19](#)]: Explanation of past tense *passato prossimo*.

Bibliography

- [Fil19] Michael San Filippo. The Italian Passato Prossimo. 2019. URL: <https://www.thoughtco.com/italian-present-perfect-tense-2011710>.
- [Rag63] Olga Ragusa. Essential Italian Grammar. Dover Publications, 1963.